

Hamilton, now adorning the scarlet red of Ferrari, was visibly chuffed at his successor's victory, embracing Antonelli and former race engineer Peter Bonnington ahead of the podium ceremony. There was more cause for celebration for the Briton. A third-place finish marked a first podium for the Scuderia in his 26th race, at the very scene of his sprint race victory from last year.

His battle for the final podium place with teammate Charles Leclerc, which involved multiple passes and repasses, was a big boost for supporters of engine-led overtaking manoeuvres enforced by the new regulations. Hamilton described it as "one of the most enjoyable races I've had", with Leclerc adding on the radio that he "enjoyed" the battle. For the first time since his move, Hamilton looked on equal footing with his 'senior' teammate, managing to find the sweet spot better than the Monegasque driver during practice and qualifying.

Away from the glee and glamour at the top end of the field, it was a forgettable race for defending constructors' champion McLaren. Both Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri (for the second race in succession) failed to even start due to different electrical issues related to the power unit.

Piastri has failed to complete even a single lap this season after his crash en route to the grid in the opener. The Aussie found a way to bring some humour despite his distress, joking that this was the most F1 action he had watched from the sidelines in a long time.

Red Bull Racing, too, had a disappointing outing, with four-time champ Max Verstappen forced to retire with a cooling issue. Teammate Isack Hadjar managed to take away some gloom with an eighth-place finish despite spinning on the opening lap. Haas' Ollie Bearman and Alpine's Pierre Gasly cashed in on the upper midfield teams' misery, collecting a rich haul of points after finishing fifth and sixth, respectively.

The race result in Shanghai will be a wake-up call for Russell, who will realise that he will be tested to the limit by his talented junior teammate in his quest for a drivers' world title. A see-saw battle between the two Mercedes cars will also keep Ferrari within reach. Fred Vasseur's team will hope it can crack the next engine upgrade to reel in their quicker rival and tighten the race for both championship titles.

REUTERS



MotoGP



Aprilia Racing's blinding start to the MotoGP season continued with a 1-2 finish at the Brazilian Grand Prix.

Marco Bezzecchi (**below**) earned his second win of the season and fourth in succession in the top tier, ahead of teammate Jorge Martin. Concerns surrounding tyre degradation and the soaring heat forced the organisers to cut the race from 31 laps to 23 and the two Aprilia riders had a smooth passage to the chequered flag. The pair now leads the rider's championship standings ahead of KTM's Pedro Acosta, who could only manage a seventh place finish. Defending champion Marc Marquez, who had won the sprint race a day prior, missed out on a podium place after a race-long tussle with VR46 Racing's Fabio di Giannantonio.



AFP